

Transportation Solutions Operating Benchmark

Two-page source brief | Four structurally distinct archetypes | Analysis date: July 18, 2026

SUBVERTICAL THESIS

Four models require separate estimates: railcar leasing, locomotive leasing, airport GSE leasing and outsourced yard logistics. Asset lessors earn higher margins with heavier reinvestment; yard logistics is labor-led, lower-margin and much lighter-capital.

METRIC	ESTIMATE	RATIONALE / EVIDENCE
Revenue growth	Railcar 4% Loco 6% GSE 8% Yard 7%	Rationale. Railcar growth is price, fleet additions and utilization; locomotives add modernization demand. GSE gains from outsourcing and electrification. Yard growth is new sites and cross-sell. Support / caveat. VTG reported strong tank-wagon but weaker intermodal utilization; Akiem has placed major orders and completed a EUR1.52 billion green refinancing... CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
EBITDA margin	Railcar 58% Loco 62% GSE 30% Yard 14%	Rationale. Rail earns high lease spreads, tempered by maintenance and off-lease drag. GSE bears technician and workshop cost. Yard payroll and shift efficiency cap margins. Support / caveat. Akiem's official 2021 transaction data showed roughly EUR150 million EBITDA on EUR220 million revenue. CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
Maintenance capex / revenue	Railcar 18% Loco 18% GSE 14% Yard 4%	Rationale. Wagons need overhaul and replacement; locomotives add ERTMS and compliance work. GSE needs refurbishment and batteries. Yard sustains tractors and tech only. Support / caveat. VTG spent EUR536 million on fixed assets in 2024, mainly new wagons and fleet maintenance. Akiem is upgrading about 250 locomotives for ERTMS. CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
Post-maintenance capex conversion	Railcar 69% Loco 71% GSE 55% Yard 71%	Rationale. The measure is (EBITDA minus maintenance capex) / EBITDA, not full free cash flow. Support / caveat. Ranges are calculated directly from each archetype's normalized EBITDA and maintenance-capex assumptions and exclude interest, taxes, working... CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
Initial contract tenor	Railcar 4 yrs Loco 7 yrs GSE 5 yrs Yard 3 yrs	Rationale. High unit value and approvals require longer locomotive terms. Wagon and GSE packages are medium term. Yard mobilization needs less legal duration than large assets. Support / caveat. VTG materials describe medium-to-long-term wagon hire; Akiem supports rolling stock through handback; TCR is described as having long-term... CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
Effective customer tenure	Railcar 9 yrs Loco 12 yrs GSE 9 yrs Yard 7 yrs	Rationale. Customer life outlasts one asset or site contract. Support / caveat. The report cites fleet integration in industrial flows, Akiem's framework and lifecycle support, TCR's long-term relationships, and Lazer customer... CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
Utilization exposure	Railcar Moderate Loco Moderate GSE Moderate-High Yard High	Rationale. Rail depends on paid deployment and redeployment; locomotive downtime is concentrated. GSE adds ramp use and spare fleets. Yard depends on productive labor hours. Support / caveat. VTG's intermodal utilization weakened while tank wagons stayed high. TCR discusses idle-fleet waste and telematics right-sizing. CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
New-unit / customer payback	Railcar 9 yrs Loco 10 yrs GSE 5.5 yrs Yard 1.5 yrs	Rationale. Rail needs multiple placements and residual value. GSE is cheaper but service-heavy. Yard launch spend is mainly recruiting, training, limited equipment and tech. Support / caveat. All ranges are triangulated from fully burdened investment and unit- or site-level cash contribution after direct cost and a maintenance reserve... CONFIDENCE: MIXED BY ARCHETYPE
B2B versus B2C	All models Predominantly B2B	Rationale. Customers buy capital relief, uptime, compliance and outsourcing. Contracts sit with operators, authorities, airports, handlers, industrial firms and 3PLs. Support / caveat. Each company's official customer description is institutional; the report found no economically relevant direct B2C revenue stream in the... CONFIDENCE: HIGH

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HOW TO READ THE UNIVERSE

Five businesses map to four models: railcar, locomotive, airport GSE and yard logistics. The economic unit shifts from an earning asset, to a station fleet package, to a site contract and productive service hour.

VTG

WHAT IT DOES

Leases and manages European freight wagons for industrial shippers and rail operators.

ECONOMIC MODEL

Unit: earning wagon; revenue: recurring lease plus services. Customers avoid capital and secure compliant, cargo-specific capacity.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

2024: EUR405m operating cash flow and EUR536m fixed-asset investment, mainly new wagons and maintenance; tank utilization stayed high while intermodal softened.

Akiem

WHAT IT DOES

Leases and maintains locomotives and some passenger rolling stock across Europe.

ECONOMIC MODEL

Unit: locomotive under lease/full service. Operators outsource scarce, compliant traction.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

2021: 600+ locomotives, 46 passenger trains, about EUR220m revenue and EUR150m EBITDA. A EUR1.52bn 2026 refinancing supports growth; about 250 locomotives are receiving ERTMS.

Air Rail

WHAT IT DOES

AIR RAIL, S.L. leases, maintains and refurbishes airport GSE; it also has rail activities.

ECONOMIC MODEL

Unit: deployed GSE/station package. Rental, maintenance, parts and resale solve airline/handler capex and uptime needs. Airport service embeds relationships; rebids and transfer friction cause churn.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

IFM owns 75%. March 2026: 4,700+ units, about 60 airports, eight countries and 68% of motorized units electric.

TCR

WHAT IT DOES

Rents, maintains, refurbishes and electrifies GSE for airlines, handlers and airports.

ECONOMIC MODEL

Unit: GSE/airport fleet package. Full-service rent and lifecycle services solve turnaround uptime and capital needs. Workshops, technicians and spares embed TCR; handler rebids drive churn.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

44,000+ assets, 100+ workshops, 1,800+ employees, 24 countries and 200+ airports. GIP's March 2026 acquisition agreement was expected to close in Q3.

Lazer Logistics

WHAT IT DOES

Runs warehouse and industrial yards using drivers, equipment, processes and technology.

ECONOMIC MODEL

Unit: site contract/service hour. Recurring site and labor revenue solves trailer-flow bottlenecks. Lazer staffs and supervises yards; integration supports retention, while rebids, closures and volume loss cause churn.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

EQT reports 550+ sites, 5,000 employees, 6,000 fleet assets and 9m annual service hours. Lazer is outsourced operations, not an asset-leasing benchmark.

KEY DILIGENCE QUESTIONS

1. Do not blend the four archetypes: the asset-owner versus labor-operator distinction drives margins, capex... | 2. Private-company maintenance capex is the weakest metric; obtain gross replacement, refurbishment... | 3. Measure paid utilization by asset family, off-lease days and redeployment cost rather than relying on...